

Official UPSC Civil Services Examination Syllabus & Compendi

Section 1: Prelims Structure

Preliminary Examination Architecture (Stage 1)

The Preliminary Examination consists of two objective type (multiple-choice) papers carrying 400 marks total: Paper I (General Studies, 200 marks, 100 questions) and Paper II (CSAT, 200 marks, 80 questions).

Paper I determines the Prelims cutoff for Mains qualification. Paper II is qualifying in nature, requiring a mandatory minimum score of 33% (66 marks). Each incorrect answer incurs negative marking of one-third (0.333) of the marks assigned to that question.

Core subjects: Current events of national and international importance, History of India and Indian National Movement, Indian and World Geography, Indian Polity and Governance, Economic and Social Development, General issues on Environmental Ecology, and General Science.

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Section 2: Mains Structure

Mains Written Examination Scheme (Stage 2 - 1750 Marks)

The Mains Written Examination assesses in-depth analytical intellect through nine subjective papers. Papers A (Indian Language) and B (English) are qualifying (25% qualifying threshold) and not counted in merit ranking.

Seven merit papers (250 marks each = 1750 marks total): Paper I (Essay), Paper II (GS-I: Heritage & Culture, History & Geography of World and Society), Paper III (GS-II: Governance, Constitution, Polity, Social Justice & International Relations), Paper IV (GS-III: Technology, Economic Development, Bio-diversity, Environment, Security & Disaster Management), Paper V (GS-IV: Ethics, Integrity & Aptitude), Paper VI & VII (Optional Subject Papers 1 & 2).

The Personality Test (Interview) carries 275 marks, bringing the grand aggregate to 2025 marks for the final merit list and All-India service allocation (IAS, IFS, IPS, Central Services Group A).

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Section 3: Ethics & Case Studies

General Studies Paper IV (Ethics, Integrity & Aptitude) Framework

GS Paper IV evaluates candidates'™ integrity, moral philosophy, approach to issues relating to probity in public life, and conflict-resolution skills in public governance.

Section A covers foundational concepts: Human values, lessons from ethical philosophers (Socrates, Plato, Kant's™ Deontology, Mill's™ Utilitarianism, Gandhi's™ Seven Social Sins), emotional intelligence, and Nolan Committee principles of public life (Selflessness, Integrity, Objectivity, Accountability, Openness, Honesty, Leadership).

Section B consists of practical situational case studies testing administrative decision-making under ethical dilemmas, whistleblower dilemmas, pressure from political masters, and emergency crisis management.